FIXING THE ILLS OF HEALTHCARE

After steering the country through the pandemic, the health ministry is concentrating on the gaps exposed

By Sonali Acharjee



THE SUDDEN, GATHERING storm of a pandemic, the gradual outbreak, its spikes and troughs, and the immediate health needs of millions in acute distress—the Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW) has been constantly under the spotlight for the past two years. Most of the health resources of the ministry, too, were deployed to manage the pandemic. Nonetheless, amidst the turmoil, the ministry has successfully initiated a variety of other schemes in the past three years.

Leading the ministry from 2021 is Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya, a believer in 'quick' communication who has separate WhatsApp groups with state health ministers and senior ministry officials. Mandaviya was honoured by Unicef for contributing to women's menstrual hygiene by using the chain of Jan Aushadhi Kendras to sell 100 million biodegradable sanitary pads.

Keeping future outbreaks in mind, the ministry has set up the Centre for One Health in Nagpur, which will carry out surveillance of bacterial, viral and parasitic infections. To bolster defences further, the PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission Scheme will focus on preparing health systems for pandemic responses. "The management of the pandemic, especially the recent Omicron wave, has shown the world the power of strong political will, self-reliance through Atma Nirbharta and innovation powered by technology," says Mandaviya.

After enduring the pain and distress of the second Covid-19 wave, there was the undeniable success of the vaccination drive. On October 21, 2021, the ministry celebrated the landmark achievement of the one billionth Covid-19 vac-

WHAT'S DONE

- The Union Budget allocated Rs 86,200 crore to healthcare, a hike of 16 per cent
- One billion doses of Covid vaccines administered in nine months
- Major schemes started under National Digital Health Programme
- Greater focus for mental health
- More medical colleges being set up in district hospitals to address the shortage of qualified doctors
- Boost for dedicated clinics to focus on diseases like cancer, stroke and diabetes

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- India's doctor: patient ratio is 1:1,511; the WHO norm is 1:1,000. There is an urgent need for trained nurses too
- Need for more hospital beds
- India has to have more primary and secondary healthcare centres
- Non-communicable diseases like cancer and heart disease are a national burden, need to be prevented